NEPQ Phase 3 — Problem Awareness

Cheat sheet · 5 Nov 2026

Purpose

Help the prospect find and name their **real problem** themselves: what it is, how long it has lasted, what causes it, and what it is costing them. You guide; they diagnose.

Do / Don't

Do	Don't
Start positive ("What do you like about it?")	Attack their current strategy
Ask neutral, open questions	Tell them what their problem is
Drill into vague answers ("What do you mean by…?")	Accept "it's fine" or "I wish it was faster" at face value
Be patient and reflect their words back	Rush to your solution

The question flow

Step	Example question
1. Open the door	"Is there anything you'd change about how you're doing it?"
2. Clarify	"What do you mean by faster / more consistent?"
3. Duration	"How long has that been a problem?"
4. Cause	"What do you think is causing that?"
5. Impact	"How has that affected your motivation / results / business?"

Why it works: people defend what you criticise, but they believe what they say themselves. If they spot the gap in their own words, the case for change is theirs, and your solution later feels like help, not a pitch.

Applied to TRB: gym and PT studio owners

Their goal from Phase 1 is usually **more new members**. Their situation from Phase 2 is how they get members and reviews now (word of mouth, Instagram, asking in person). Now dig into the gap:

Step	TRB version
Open the door	"Is there anything you'd change about how new members find you?"
Clarify	"When you say reviews are hit and miss, what does that look like week to week?"
Duration	"How long has it been like that?"
Cause	"What usually gets in the way of asking happy members for a review?"
Impact	"When someone searches gyms near me and sees a competitor with more recent reviews, what do you think that costs you each month?"

Listen for: "I forget to ask", "no time", "reviews are old", "competitors rank above us", "quiet months". Log the exact words in your CRM Pains tab; they become your pitch and your website copy.

Self-check after each call

☐ Did they name the problem in their own words?

☐ Do I know how long it has lasted, and why?

☐ Do I know what it is costing them (members, money, motivation)?

☐ Did I drill into every vague answer?

☐ Did I avoid pitching too early?

Next phase: Solution Awareness, where the prospect pictures what life looks like with the problem solved.